

When does relational listening feel self-congruent, and under what conditions is it emotionally costly for listeners?

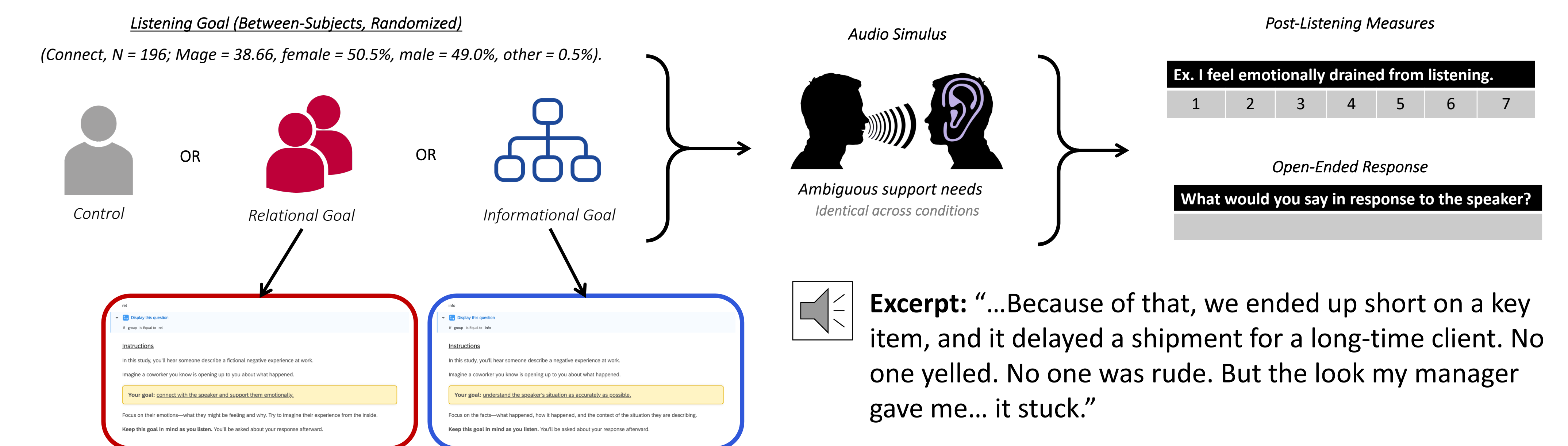
1. Background

Imagine a coworker confiding about a stressful mistake at work. As the listener, you can comfort them (**relational goal**) or help solve the problem (**informational goal**), and in many real conversations organizational norms guide you to follow both supportive and solution-focused expectations. The Conversational Circumplex (Yeomans et al., 2022) captures this relational–informational tension, similar to how clinicians balance empathy with diagnostic focus (Jodi Halpern, 2003).

Building on emotional labor theory (Hochschild, 1983), we ask whether assigning relational versus informational listening goals changes listeners' experience and when those effects depend on goal–person fit.

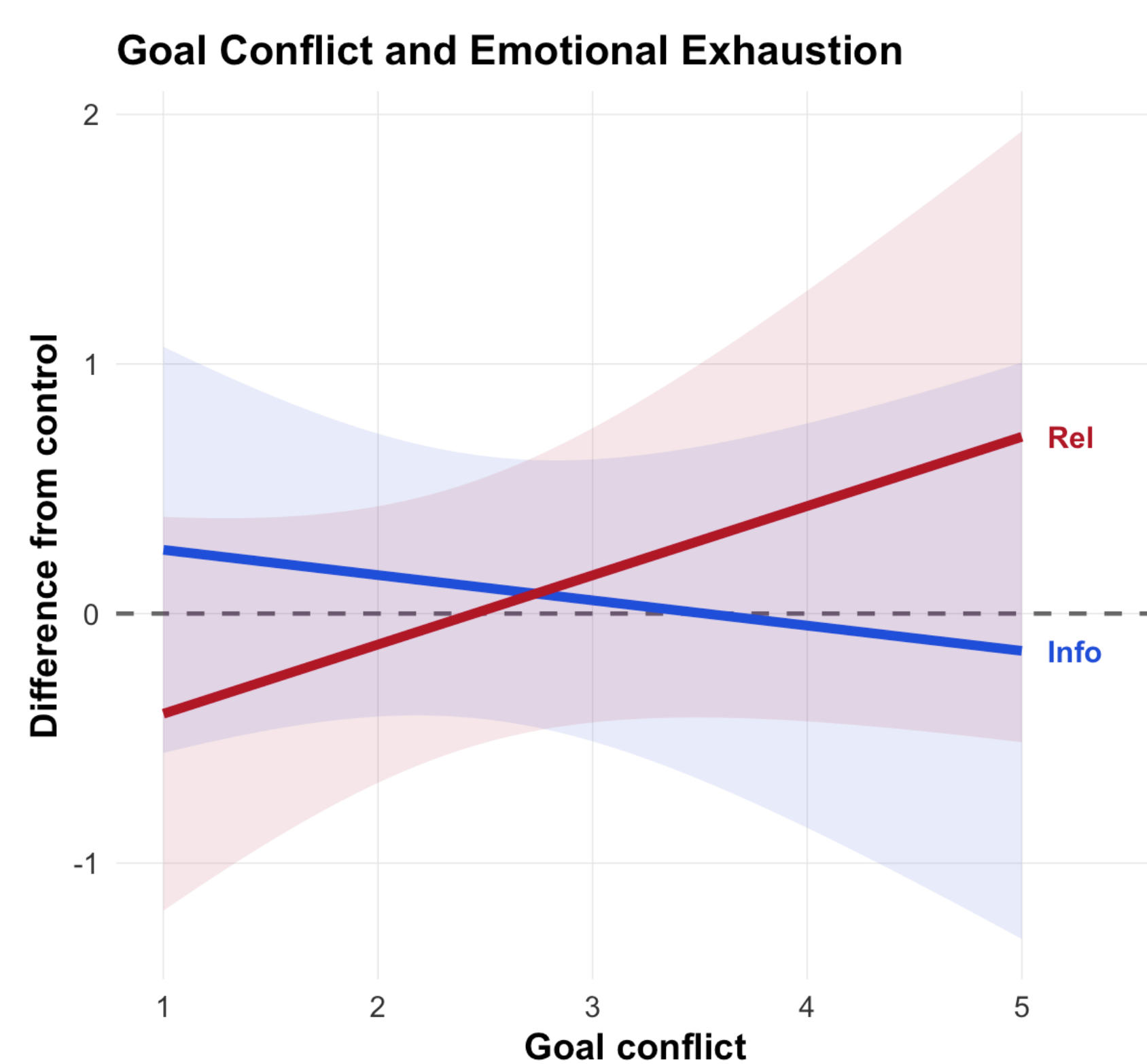
- (H1) Relational listening goals increase goal conflict, which in turn increases emotional exhaustion.
 (H2) Goal–person fit moderates the effect of listening goals on response self-congruence.
 (H3) Higher goal conflict predicts lower willingness to re-engage.

2. Pilot Study



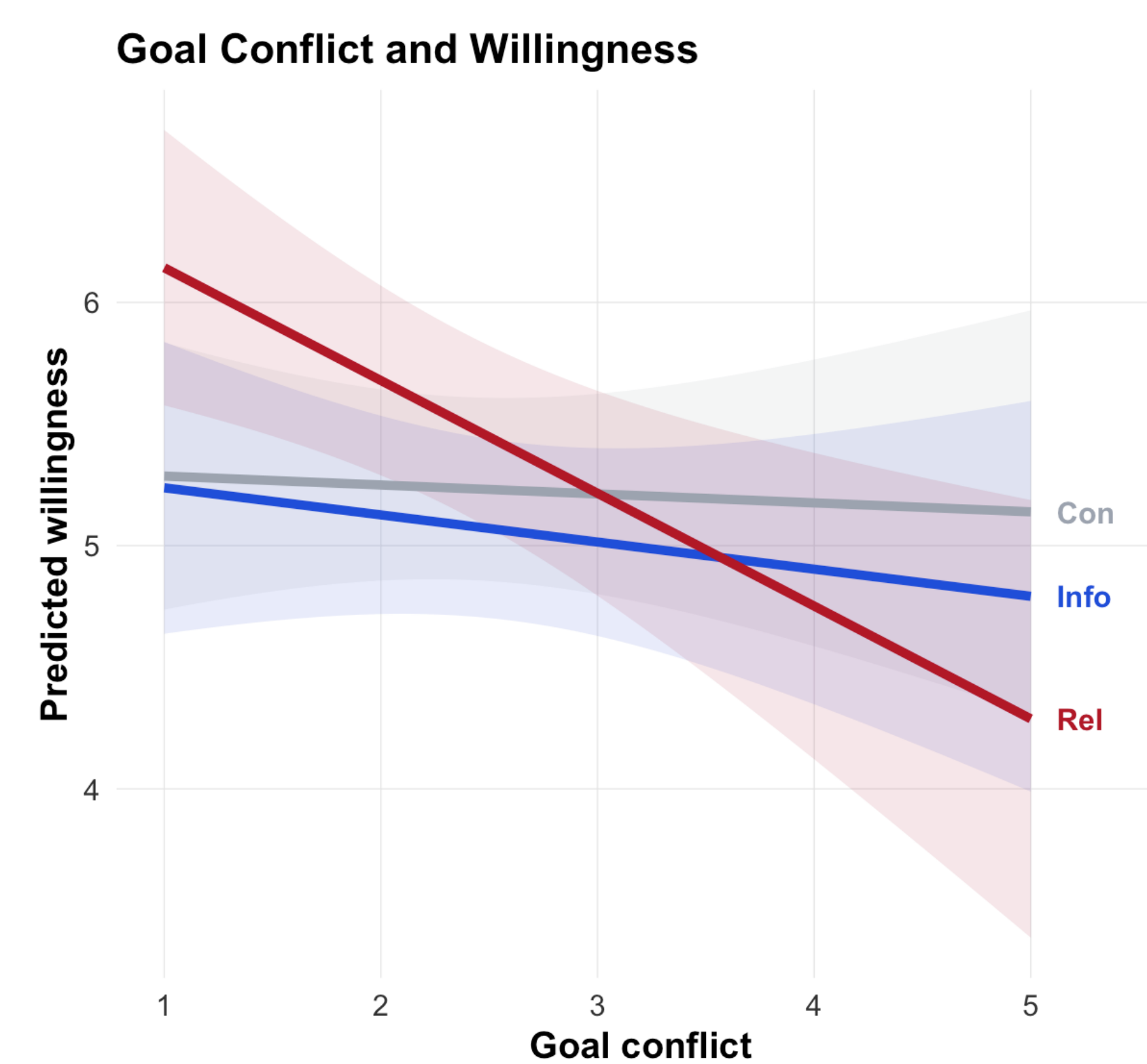
3. Results

Emotional Exhaustion. As goal conflict increases, relational listening becomes more emotionally exhausting than other goals.



Exhaustion x Conflict		
	b	sig
Rel	0.52	p = .001
Info	0.15	p = .324
Con	0.25	p = .085

Willingness to re-engage. As goal conflict increases, participants assigned relational goals report lower willingness to listen to the speaker again.



Willingness x Conflict		
	b	sig
Rel	-0.46	p = .003
Info	-0.11	p = .463
Con	-0.037	p = .801

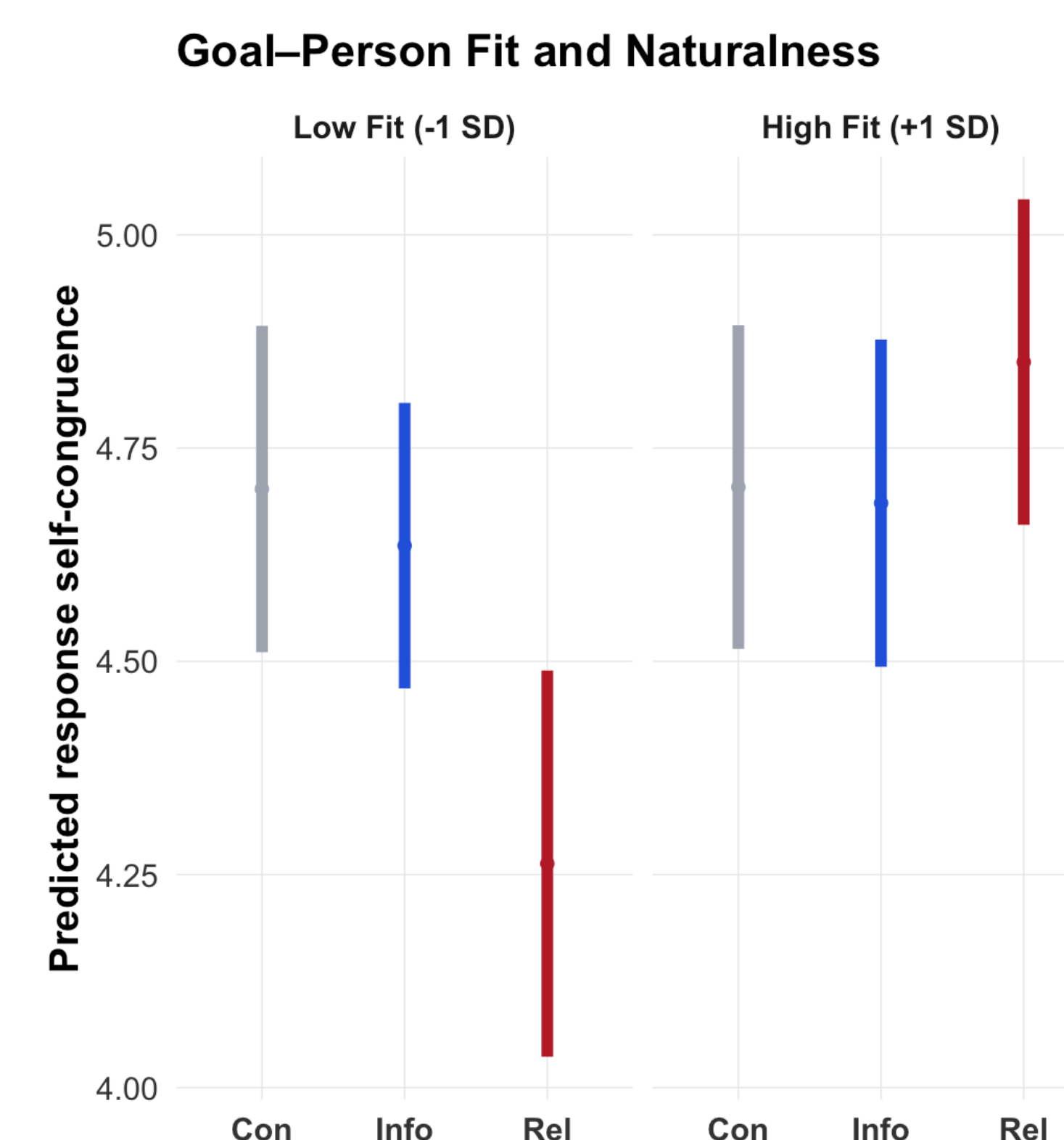
Emotional exhaustion:
 "I feel emotionally drained from listening."

Goal conflict :
 "I felt torn between trying to understand the speaker's story and supporting them emotionally."

Willingness to reengage:
 "I would be willing to listen if this speaker came to me again with a similar story."

Response Self-Congruence:
 "My response felt like something I would actually say in real life."

Response self-congruence. Under relational listening goals, low goal–person fit corresponded to responses that felt much less like oneself.



Text analysis. In the relational goal condition, participants exerted more effort, writing significantly longer responses.

4. Discussion

Discussion. Across hypotheses, results show that relational listening is not uniformly beneficial for listeners.

- Goal conflict increased emotional exhaustion under relational goals, even at relatively low levels of conflict, affecting a majority of listeners (H1).
- Response authenticity depended on goal–person fit rather than the relational goal itself (H2).
- When relational responses felt less natural, listeners experienced greater goal conflict and became less willing to re-engage (H3).

Future Directions. Future work should examine whether listening goals can be matched to individual tendencies to reduce emotional costs, when inauthentic relational listening is socially or organizationally worthwhile, and how inauthentic effort manifests in language, timing, or nonverbal cues.

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